

World War I

In 1914 tensions that had been simmering in Europe came to a head. War broke out and quickly spread across the world. Fought between two powerful groups of countries (the Allies and the Central Powers), it was the biggest war the world had ever seen.



GERMAN FOKKER
Dr.I TRIPLANE

28 JUNE, 1914

Archduke Franz Ferdinand of Austria-Hungary is assassinated, with his wife, Sophie, in Serbia. A month later, Austria-Hungary declares war on Serbia.

1914

THE WAR TO END ALL WARS

When the war began, people believed it would be over quickly. In fact, it lasted for four years and more than 65 million men were called upon to fight.

12 AUGUST, 1914

One by one, countries take sides until war has broken out over most of Europe.



Lifebelt from the RMS Lusitania

7 MAY, 1915

Germany sinks the RMS Lusitania, a luxury British passenger ship, killing more than 1,000 passengers.

23 MAY, 1915

Italy enters the war on the side of the Allies and prepares to invade its neighbour, Austria-Hungary.



Italian army ID tag

1 JULY, 1916

The Battle of the Somme begins in France. By the time it ends in November, more than 300,000 men will die.



Battlefield site, Somme, France

17 DECEMBER, 1917

Following a revolution in Russia, the new government makes peace with Germany and leaves the war.



Russian helmet plate

3 NOVEMBER, 1918

German sailors mutiny. Austria-Hungary makes peace with the Allies.

28 JUNE, 1919

The Treaty of Versailles is signed and the war officially ends.

1919

SEPTEMBER-OCTOBER 1914

First trenches are dug along the Western Front in France and Belgium.

24 DECEMBER, 1914

British and German soldiers call an unofficial truce over Christmas.



Ottoman army medal

APRIL 1915 - JANUARY 1916

The Allies fight Ottoman troops at Gallipoli, suffering disastrous casualties.

12 FEBRUARY, 1916

Battle of Verdun begins.



Fortified turret, Verdun, France

31 MAY, 1916

The Battle of Jutland starts - the only major sea battle of the war. Britain claims victory, despite suffering heavy losses.

JANUARY 1917

Britain attacks the Ottoman Empire again, this time by landing in Palestine and pushing north through the desert to the city of Damascus.

6 APRIL, 1917

President Woodrow Wilson leads the USA into the war on the side of the Allies.

15 JULY, 1918

Second Battle of the Marne begins, near Paris.

3 AUGUST, 1918

The Allies win the Battle of the Marne. The German army collapses.

11 NOVEMBER, 1918

Germany agrees to an armistice and all fighting stops.



Memorial to the missing (near Thiepval, France), built 1932

A CONTINENT AT WAR

The two main European arenas of the war were the Western Front, between Belgium and France, and the Eastern Front, which was mainly in Russia.

KEY

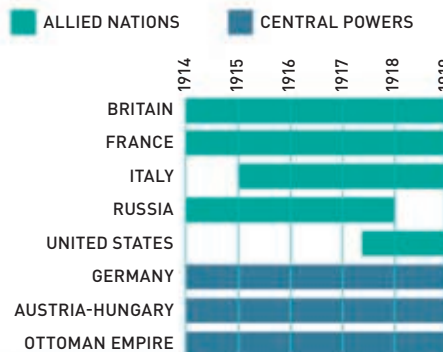
- Neutral
- Allied Nations
- Central Powers
- Western Front
- Eastern Front

EUROPE IN 1916



TAKING SIDES

By the end of 1914, almost all of Europe had taken sides in the war. Only a few countries remained neutral.



CASUALTIES OF WAR

The cost of the war in human lives was enormous. More than 30 million men were killed or injured, and some battles were so devastating that thousands died in a single day.



AMBULANCE CART

1 JULY - 18 NOVEMBER 1916

Battle of the Somme

1,219,201

21 FEBRUARY - 18 DECEMBER 1916

Battle of Verdun

976,000

11 JULY - 10 NOVEMBER 1917

Third Battle of Ypres (Passchendaele)

848,614

TOTAL CASUALTIES FROM THE BLOODIEST BATTLES OF WWI

TRENCHES

Both sides built long trenches as a defence against long-range weapons. Soon, there was stalemate, with neither side able to advance into the other's territory. Life in the trenches was hard. Soldiers fought, ate, and slept there, sometimes for weeks on end.



MESS TIN



TRENCH AXE



SEWING KIT



GAS MASK



FOLDING SHOVEL



CROSS-SECTION OF A TYPICAL WORLD WAR I BATTLEFIELD